

Cat Sundown Syndrome Guide — Action Checklist

PRINT THIS PAGE AND KEEP IT SOMEWHERE VISIBLE

PREPARE FOR THE VET VISIT

- ☐ **Call your vet and specifically request a senior workup to investigate nighttime vocalization, because generic wellness exams often miss the treatable conditions causing this behavior.:** Call your vet and specifically request a senior workup to investigate nighttime vocalization, because generic wellness exams often miss the treatable conditions causing this behavior.
- ☐ **Request a Total T4 thyroid panel to check for hyperthyroidism, since this common condition in cats over 10 causes metabolic overdrive and loud nighttime vocalization.:** Request a Total T4 thyroid panel to check for hyperthyroidism, since this common condition in cats over 10 causes metabolic overdrive and loud nighttime vocalization.
- ☐ **Request blood pressure measurement at the vet visit, because hypertension in older cats causes disorientation, head tilts, and crying out that responds well to medication.:** Request blood pressure measurement at the vet visit, because hypertension in older cats causes disorientation, head tilts, and crying out that responds well to medication.
- ☐ **Request joint palpation for arthritis screening during the exam, since cats hide pain exceptionally well and may yowl at night because settling into a painful position causes discomfort.:** Request joint palpation for arthritis screening during the exam, since cats hide pain exceptionally well and may yowl at night because settling into a painful position causes discomfort.

ADAPT YOUR HOME ENVIRONMENT

- ☐ **Add nightlights throughout your home so your disoriented senior cat can navigate hallways and locate her bed, litter box, and food without panicking in the dark.:** Add nightlights throughout your home so your disoriented senior cat can navigate hallways and locate her bed, litter box, and food without panicking in the dark.
 - ☐ **Place multiple water bowls and litter boxes in accessible locations on each floor, because a confused cat may forget where resources are or become unable to find them.:** Place multiple water bowls and litter boxes in accessible locations on each floor, because a confused cat may forget where resources are or become unable to find them.
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- ☐ **Keep your cat's bed, food, and favorite resting spots in consistent locations every night to reduce confusion and prevent the circling that triggers nighttime distress.:** Keep your cat's bed, food, and favorite resting spots in consistent locations every night to reduce confusion and prevent the circling that triggers nighttime distress.
- ☐ **Set a consistent evening routine with regular feeding times and calm interaction before bed, because predictable daily patterns help anchor a confused senior cat's sense of time.:** Set a consistent evening routine with regular feeding times and calm interaction before bed, because predictable daily patterns help anchor a confused senior cat's sense of time.

CARE FOR YOURSELF TOO

- ☐ **Acknowledge that caregiver exhaustion is real and valid, because caring for a confused senior cat is emotionally draining and you cannot help her if you are completely depleted.:** Acknowledge that caregiver exhaustion is real and valid, because caring for a confused senior cat is emotionally draining and you cannot help her if you are completely depleted.
- ☐ **Connect with online communities or local support groups for owners of senior cats, because talking to others facing the same challenges reduces isolation and provides practical coping strategies.:** Connect with online communities or local support groups for owners of senior cats, because talking to others facing the same challenges reduces isolation and provides practical coping strategies.
- ☐ **Ask your vet about respite care options or daytime help, because taking breaks prevents burnout and allows you to provide better care for your cat long-term.:** Ask your vet about respite care options or daytime help, because taking breaks prevents burnout and allows you to provide better care for your cat long-term.
- ☐ **Talk to your own doctor about the physical toll of interrupted sleep and caregiver stress, because your health matters and burnout compromises your ability to care for your pet.:** Talk to your own doctor about the physical toll of interrupted sleep and caregiver stress, because your health matters and burnout compromises your ability to care for your pet.